

- You'll need to have a plan of attack for the price you drop out at and then rejoin at, relative to your own budget, instead of how much you assume those around you have to spend. You may start off bidding until you are within ten per cent of your limit, and leave your last few thousand for a late push. If there are several bidders in the mix when you decide to take a break, you'll need more in the tank to run them down towards the end. It's an imprecise art.

The aggressor

This is an intimidation tactic – in the lingo of *Seinfeld*, you have 'hand'. You want your competition to think you have stamina and large funds, and you establish this ruse at the outset by making the first bid. This type of bidder is able to set the speed of the auction and will always respond to an opponent's bid immediately, within a second or two, applying excruciating pressure. You bid rapidly and robustly to your limit before going silent – you don't take a breath until you have run out of funds.

Pros

- You will freak out your competition.

Cons

- You need to have done impeccable research on the market value of the property to be able to make an opening bid that is in the sweet spot. If it's not high enough, the auctioneer will ask you directly for a greater sum, and if you don't provide it, you'll look like a doofus, and the jig is up – nobody will fear you. If this happens, the auctioneer will ask for other offers or make a vendor bid to lift the price to an acceptable level to start genuine bidding with a chance to reach the reserve; otherwise, auctions would drag on for hours.
- Hardened self-belief is not an attribute many first home buyers have, but you'd need this to maintain the pace and pressure required.

Tips to avoiding stuffing up at auction

In the hundreds of auctions I have watched as a journalist, I've seen some understandably blundering techniques from first home buyers. Nerves are to